

fridayReview

THE HINDU



A SERIES WITH THE STRINGS

Kumaresh R. on unlocking the violin's rhythmic potential **p2**



Shailaja Tripathi

In the dark interiors of the Ajanta caves, where light barely reaches the frescoes walls, filmmaker, photographer and art historian Benoy K. Behl discovered not just ancient paintings, but an entire philosophy of life.

At a recent illustrated lecture at the Bangalore International Centre (BIC), organised in memory of nuclear scientist M.R. Srinivasan and presented by his daughter, Sharada Srinivasan, professor at the National Institute of Advanced Studies, Benoy traced how photography led him from the darkness of nuclear-reactor buildings to ancient caves and temples.

He credits Srinivasan's encouragement in the late 1980s, when he was chairman of the Atomic Energy Commission, for shaping his photographic journey. "By documenting the dimly-lit nuclear power plants, I developed the patience that helped me capture the paintings visible only in orangish light," said Benoy at the talk. He is right. Many of us can recall seeing these orange-hued murals in our school textbooks.

The Ajanta Caves, a UNESCO World Heritage Site in Maharashtra, is carved into a horseshoe-shaped cliff overlooking the Waghora River, dating from the second century BCE to about 480 CE. Their rock-cut monasteries and shrines preserve some of the finest ancient Indian mural paintings.

"However, for decades, these paintings couldn't be studied properly. The ancient caves are dark and strong lights are not permitted," Benoy explained. "Photography, too, is prohibited to protect the murals from flash exposure. Earlier images often suffered from glare."

Photographing the Ajanta murals became a two-year exercise in patience and precision for Benoy. In 1991, he spent five weeks documenting the frescoes, working from morning until closing time, often stopping for only a 15-minute lunch break. Though the results drew praise from media and scholars such as Karl Khandalavala and Stella Kramrisch, Benoy was not satisfied with the outcome. "As I saw my photographs repeatedly, I felt there was actually room for improvement."

Shantanu Datta

In the gathering dusk, Shillong's sky is a pale shade of purple. A drizzle that turns into bountiful rain ushers in a night that comes alive with a vibrant rhythm. Nothing is visible, save the illumination from shopfronts and the occasional flash of red and blue lights across the roundabout where pop band Colours offers a spirited accompaniment to a bustling street food market at Police Bazar.

If there were no stars in the sky, it was because they had chosen to descend upon a nearby Evening Club to form a unique constellation – Bluesmen of Meghalaya (BoM). Wielding a friendly axe with six strings embedded, the musicians lit up the cosy confines of the storied music pub of 1958 to celebrate World Music Day 2026.

Presented by Mawjam Event Network and The Lou Majaw Foundation, the night featured seven bands paying tribute to Shillong, the rock capital of India. After an hour-long set by each, the finale, in true BoM tradition,



Sound of Shillong

Bluesmen of Meghalaya showcased the continuity of a musical tradition that defines India's rock capital

became an epic jam. The understudies joined their idols for an all-star presentation, joyfully commemorating a bond that has been cemented over decades with unique tenets of the blues as the backbone of modern popular music.

Some of the earliest members of Great Society, Lou's seminal band and pathfinder to Shillong's musical journey since the early 1970s, were there – Arjun 'AJ' Sen, Rudy Wallang, who hopped on board as a teenager, and later entrants such as Starly Chullai and Shepherd Star

Najiar. Alongside them were younger stars: Gregory Ford Nongrum, Lalchhandama 'LB King' Bawitlung, Tony Balsam and others. Together, they represented music's eternal message, willingly embraced by its practitioners, continuity and change.

Through a new lens

Benoy K. Behl, a master of low-light photography, on the challenges of documenting the murals of Ajanta

So in 1992, he returned to Ajanta, spending another five weeks photographing the murals all over again. The work was physically demanding. Staying at the MTDC guest house about 12 km away, Benoy travelled to the caves each day by local bus and worked until the last bus back in the evening. Inside the caves, the challenge was not just the heat and humidity but the near-darkness. The murals could only be studied under low-wattage conservation lights, whose orange cast distorted colours and had to be switched off before taking photographs.

Using an Ektachrome 100 ASA slide film and a tripod, Benoy relied on long exposures that sometimes exceeded 10 minutes. Any movement could ruin the image. "I had to be still and even not breathe hard, as there could be no allowance for camera shake," he says.

In times preceding digital photography, there was no instant feedback. The film had to be processed after he returned home before he could see the results. "I was in love with the beautiful art in front of me and could spare no effort, or even a moment, in trying to capture the compassionate lines, grace and message of the paintings," he said.

The results surprised scholars worldwide. "The then director general of the Archaeological Survey of India, M.C. Joshi, wrote to me that I had conquered the darkness of the Ajanta Caves," Benoy shared.

Until then, Ajanta's murals were often treated as isolated marvels. They were magnificent yet disconnected from later Indian painting traditions. Benoy's photographs changed that



perception.

Using the same low-light technique, he went on to document the 10th-century murals hidden within the narrow ambulatory passage of the Brihadeeswara Temple in Thanjavur, the paintings

of Badami, the Pallava murals of Panamalai and later traditions stretching northward to the Buddhist monasteries in Alchi and the Himalayas.

The lecture moved through approximately 20 Ajanta paintings,



For posterity (Clockwise from left) Inside the Ajanta Caves; 'Queen and Attendants' from Cave 3, Badami; a rare 13th century work and Bodhisattva Padmapani mural in Ajanta; and the 'Priest with Parasol' at the Brihadeeswara temple in Thanjavur. (Top) A panoramic view of the Ajanta caves. PHOTOS: GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

each revealing not merely the technical brilliance but emotional depth. Among them was the celebrated 'Mahajanaka Jataka' from Cave 1, narrating the story of Prince Mahajanaka of Mithila, who renounced worldly life. It was not the narrative alone that captivated Benoy. One particular detail continues to stay with him: two men watching the Bodhisattva

Mahajanaka ride away toward the forest. "I call this detail 'The Glance of Compassion'." For Benoy, the power of Ajanta lies in such moments.

"All the paintings of Ajanta are filled with an infinite grace and a sense of compassion. They reaffirm the values of life," he said, adding that the paintings do far more than merely illustrate Buddhist stories.

The lecture also revealed the extraordinary observational skill of Ajanta's painters. Benoy spoke of a mural from Cave 1 depicting women grinding spices. Through careful photography and later digital restoration, subtle gestures emerged more clearly. "One woman, in the middle, is pushing back her hair while grinding the spices," he pointed out, emphasising how everyday life entered sacred art with remarkable tenderness.

Another work discussed was 'Queen and Attendants' from Cave 3 at Badami, dating back to the sixth century CE. Benoy photographed the damaged mural in 2001 and later digitally restored it, carefully removing graffiti and accumulated damage. Technology, he believes, must serve art thoughtfully rather than overwhelm it. His own digital work aims not to invent but to recover.

Through the lecture, Benoy returned to the larger question: why did these paintings matter so deeply?

For Benoy, the answer lies in Indian aesthetics itself. "Early Indian art presents a vision of profound compassion. It sees harmony in all creation – in people, animals, flowers, trees and even the breeze." Pointing to a detailed depiction of ants climbing a tree in one of the paintings, Benoy noted how the artist sought to capture every aspect of the world.

He highlighted the Chitrastotra of the *Vishnudharmottara Purana*, regarded as one of the world's earliest treatises on art, which states that art is the greatest treasure of mankind, far more valuable than gold or jewels. "Chitrastotra laid down guidelines for the painters, and you can see that the Ajanta paintings adhered to them."

The artists of Ajanta, Benoy believes, were not merely decorators but seekers. "The making of art, in India, has been a form of meditation. A joyous rediscovery of divine glory," he said.

presented the infectious 'Too Tall to Mambo' with controlled effervescence. AJ's sublime guitar on 'Blues for Durga' was enjoyable, while Lou brought the house down with 'Hey Bartender'.

They say every end could be the start of a new beginning. So has it been with every edition of Bluesmen of Meghalaya. Thanks to Great Society and the crucible of talent it has nurtured through its chequered existence, there is this wellspring of musicianship that's quite unique to the state. One sensed it while watching drummers Vincent, Darryl Diengdoh or Sunny Manbha. They owned the 'pocket' and stayed 'locked in' with emotion and precision. Bassists such as Leon, Sydney Sangma and Mewanki Rangad rode the groove with similar dedication.

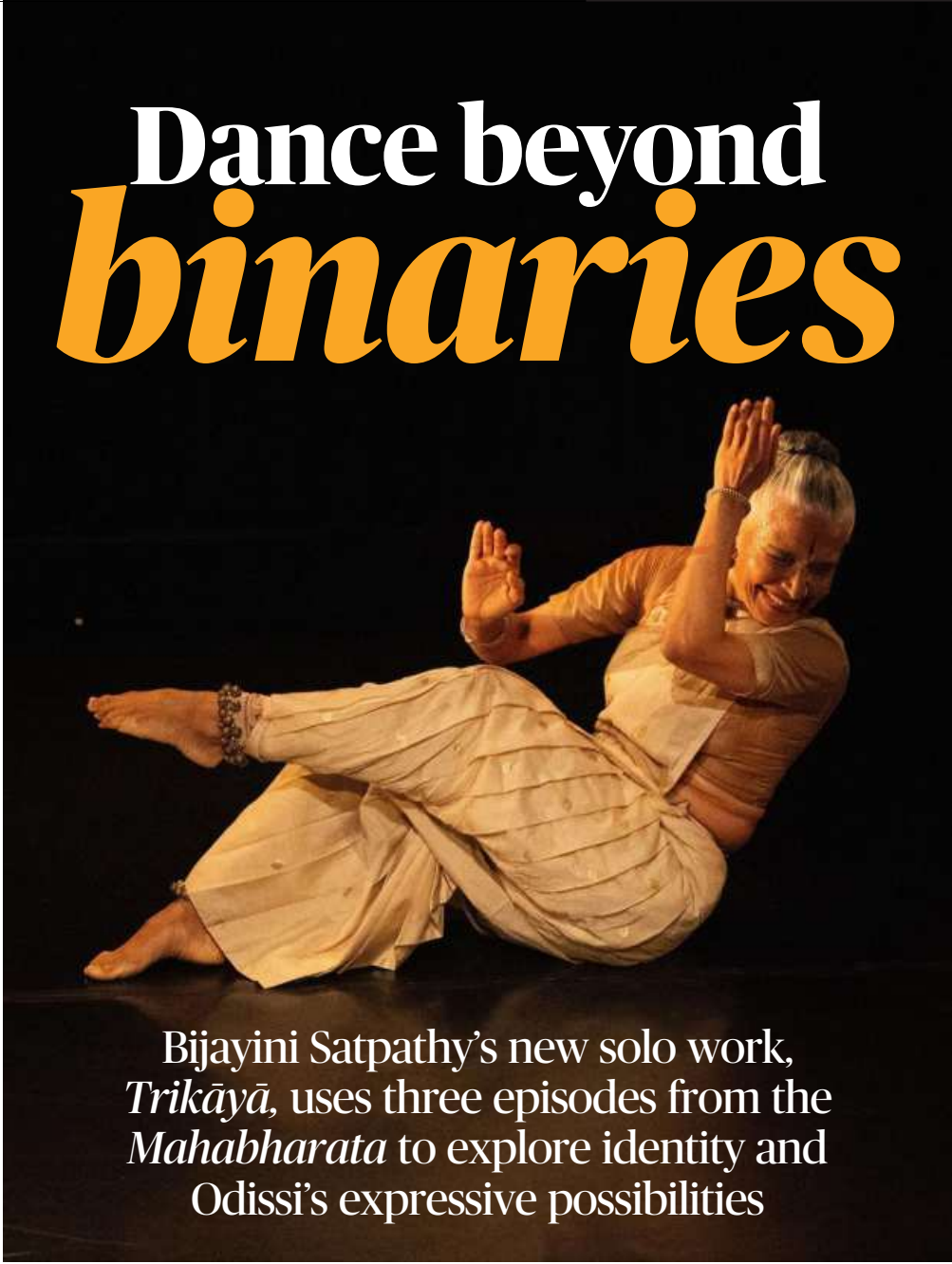
Has the blues finally found a home in Meghalaya? AJ believes it did, back in 1969 with Lou's song, 'I had a woman'. "Blues is not a set of guitar phrases by a John Mayer or a Bonamassa. It is your story to tell," he states. Today, five years since they got going, the Bluesmen of Meghalaya are trying to do just that.

Unusual confluence (From left) Srinibas Satapathy; Bijayini Satpathy and Bindhumalini Narayanaswamy. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Arundhuti Bannerjee

Trikāyā (*Three Bodies*) by Odissi exponent Bijayini Satpathy does not set out to retell the *Mahabharata*, but explores three defining moments from the epic to address a question that has followed her across years of performance – how does a classical dance form, steeped in codified masculine and feminine vocabularies, imagine a body that exists beyond binaries? The work unfolds through Arjuna preparing for battle, Urvashi’s curse after her rejection and Brihannala’s final dance before returning to the battlefield as Arjuna. Together, they become an inquiry into the gendered body in Odissi, where mythology serves not as narrative alone, but as a means to examine identity,



Bijayini Satpathy’s new solo work, *Trikāyā*, uses three episodes from the *Mahabharata* to explore identity and Odissi’s expressive possibilities

desire and vulnerability.

The premise is intellectually layered, but Bijayini never allows scholarship to overpower performance. The three vignettes flow with emotional clarity, inviting audiences into the inner worlds of the characters even when they are unfamiliar with the epic. What emerges is not merely a reinterpretation of the *Mahabharata*, but a reimagining of how classical dance itself can hold fluidity within form.

According to Bijayini, the work was born out of a question that lingered after years of performing across geographies. “I ask myself, what is the global audience seeing? Even if I give them a thread to follow, what are they really getting out of these shifts of character?”

For audiences unfamiliar with Indian mythology, she realised, the performance often transcended narrative understanding. That prompted her to delve deeper into the movement

vocabulary of Odissi. If dancers routinely inhabit multiple characters without changing costume or appearance, why are certain postures still read as masculine and feminine? And what is the language of a body that exists outside such inherited binaries? These questions eventually led her to Brihannala, Arjuna’s identity during his exile, but not before they became deeply personal.

“I realised that playing Ravana lets me do things I



was never allowed to,” says Bijayini. Growing up, anger was not an emotion girls were encouraged to express. “Girls don’t get angry. You can cry in your room, but don’t shout or scream,” she recalls being told. Dance, however, offered another possibility. “On stage, I have full licence to be who I am and to access different physical, emotional and internal spaces.”

That liberation quietly underpins *Trikāyā*. Rather than presenting Arjuna, Urvashi and Brihannala as fixed identities, Bijayini allows each character to emerge through shifts in energy, rhythm and intention. The performance resists easy definitions, inviting the audience to dwell in ambiguity instead. In doing so, Odissi opens up, not as a static tradition, but as a living language capable of questioning the very codes it has inherited.

If *Trikāyā* speaks of contemporary conversations around gender, Bijayini is careful not to frame it as

advocacy. The work, she says, grew from an artistic inquiry into Odissi itself and its possibilities. “My investment is in dance. If the work makes someone rethink a belief or question a prejudice they hold, I’ll be happy. But I’m not creating choreography as an advocacy. Every work I make is, first and foremost, a study for me.”

That distinction gives *Trikāyā* its quiet confidence. Instead of prescribing answers, it invites audiences to sit with questions. Through Arjuna’s moral conflict, Urvashi’s humiliation and Brihannala’s final dance before returning to battle, Bijayini gently dismantles conventional notions of masculinity and femininity, revealing instead shared emotional landscapes beneath them.

Equally compelling is how the performance remains rooted in the grammar of Odissi even as it stretches its expressive boundaries. Familiar movement vocabularies are neither

discarded nor rejected; instead, they are re-examined from within.

The intellectual rigour of *Trikāyā* is matched by the sensitivity of its collaborators. The choreography and performance by Bijayini sits in close dialogue with music by Bindhumalini Narayanaswamy, whose compositions lend emotional depth without overwhelming the choreography. The mardala of Sibasankar Satapathy and the flute of Srinibas Satapathy create shifting textures that move between contemplation and tension. Lighting by Deepa Dharmadhikari gently sculpts the stage, while dramaturgy by Poorna ensures conceptual clarity.

The production also reflects the spirit of G5A’s In Residency programme, which allowed the work to evolve through workshops, open rehearsals and audience conversations.

As *Trikāyā* draws to a close, the conversation gradually shifts away from gender as the central frame. The warrior awaiting battle, the apsara confronting rejection, and the dancer navigating multiple identities cease to remain mythological constructs alone. They become recognisably human.

“We all wonder: Am I visible? Am I loved? Am I isolated?” Bijayini says. “The characters become a way for us to access something much deeper within ourselves.” That, perhaps, is *Trikāyā*’s most enduring gesture.

Rather than modernising mythology, it demonstrates how a classical form can evolve from within. In Bijayini’s hands, Odissi becomes a space where inherited vocabularies are questioned with care, where movement transcends binaries, and where empathy ultimately proves more powerful than identity.



Rising notes Lydian Nadhaswaram shines on the global stage. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A symphonic celebration

Kalyan Gopalan

The audio launch of *Symphony No. 1 – New Beginnings* by Chennai-based composer and multi-instrumentalist Lydian Nadhaswaram was a celebration of imagination and perseverance. Held on World Music Day at The Music Academy, the programme brought together people across generations to watch the performance by a young composer on the global symphonic stage.

A symphony demands an understanding of the grammar of every instrument. The strings, harp, woodwinds, brass and percussion sections – each contributes to the larger musical conversation. Lydian’s work reflects this insight, bringing together diverse textures and emotions into a unified orchestral canvas. The audio-visual

presentation traced Lydian’s musical journey. Performed by the 92-member London Symphony Orchestra, the composition revealed layers of harmony. Conductor Matt Dunkley highlighted the distinct identities of all four movements, observing that such contrasts are central to the spirit of a symphony.

After completing *Thirukkural 1330*, a musical interpretation of the Tamil couplets, Lydian took up the symphony as his next challenge. He completed the digital mock-up of the composition in May. The recording later took place at Abbey Road studios in London, where Matt’s

conducting brought clarity to every musical detail.

The London Symphony Orchestra recognised Lydian as the youngest Indian and Asian composer to compose and record a symphony. Calling it a ‘people’s symphony’, Lydian dedicated the work to composers, musicians and aspiring artistes.

The symphony’s first movement ‘Allegretto’, carried an energetic spirit. The second, ‘Tranquillo’, began with a reflective cello passage before expanding through woodwinds, strings and harp. The harp established the movement’s central motif, recurring as a delicate thread through its

progression.

The composition later moved into a double harmonic major scale, introducing a dramatic shade with Middle Eastern tonal influences. The composition wound up by bringing together the sounds of the harp and cello.

The third movement, ‘Quest’, showcased the brilliance of the strings, while the final one, ‘Ascension’, rose with the power of the brass section.

Symphony No. 1 – New Beginnings stands as both a personal achievement and an invitation for Indian audiences to explore the world of symphonic music.

In the flow of tala

Violinist Kumaresh R. reflects on a creative quest that transformed his rhythmic ideas into the music series *Tala Pravaham*

Deepa Ganesh

It is not unusual for creative minds to feel the urge to carve out a unique space for themselves. Kumaresh R., of the well-known Ganesh-Kumaresh violin duo, is no exception. Over the years, the many musical conversations he shared with his brother lingered in the background, waiting for the right moment to find expression.

Tala Pravaham, a series of rhythmic explorations on the violin, is the culmination of that journey. “Ideas are an outcome of a journey,” says Kumaresh. The spark, he recalls, came as he reflected on many of those conversations.

“We spoke about the irony of equating music primarily with the voice,” he says. “Saraswati plays the veena; she doesn’t sing. Krishna plays the flute; he doesn’t sing. There are other deities too who are represented through instruments rather than the voice. Much of what we today call the Carnatic vocal style and technique actually evolved from the way instruments were played, not the other way round. The veena and the nagaswaram, for instance, have contributed immensely – the short phrases, gamakas and more.”

For Kumaresh, these examples point to a larger truth: music has always been centred on *nada* or sound itself. “Tyagaraja wrote ‘Sangeeta gnanamu’, not *Sahitya Jnanamu*. He spoke of ‘Nadopasana’. These are powerful pointers to what the very edifice of this music is. In that case, why do we always have to be a caricature of the voice?”

The idea took shape during one of his classes. “In vocal music, *sahitya* creates a progression of meaning. But on

an instrument, how do we achieve that? I composed a melody in *Ata tala*, shaping it to reflect the rhythmic possibilities of the *tala* itself.”

That, however, led to another question. If he were to present this in a concert, did he have enough material to sustain it? Vocalists have an abundance of compositions across a wide range of *talas*, thanks to generations of composers who created works in which *sangeeta* and *sahitya* exist in inseparable harmony. Instrumentalists, by contrast, have traditionally relied on these compositions to demonstrate their artistry.

“Suppose I wanted to play something in Sankeerna Jathi Jhampa *tala*. There was nothing that was uniquely conceived for violin. That was when I began creating material in different *talas*.”

The first composition was set to Dhruva *tala*, exploring the five *jathis* – *Tisra*, *Chatusra*, *Khanda*, *Misra* and *Sankeerna* – through ragas such as *Nattai*, *Kamboji*, *Purvikalyani*, *Sankarabharanam* and *Bhairavi*, respectively.

“We planned a *kutcheri* around the idea. The musicians who performed with me were

excited. It was a huge success,” he recalls.

From there, the journey continued through *Matya*, *Jhampa*, *Rupaka*, *Triputa* and *Ata talas*.

Kumaresh is now gearing up for the grand finale of the series – *Eka*. Looking back, he sees the entire project as something that unfolded organically. “Everything happened in a flow. Maybe it was the alignment of the mind with a deep craving within to create something and to find the expression I was searching for.” Every *tala*, he says, opened up a distinct creative landscape. It allowed him to explore the sonic character of different ragas while weaving them into the rhythmic architecture of each *tala*. Each *Tala Pravaham* composition is conceived as a lyrical melody in a distinct raga, uniquely crafted for a particular *jaathi* of a *tala*. In doing so, the series reveals the intersection of mathematics and music, demonstrating the seamless harmony between rhythm, melody and structure.

For Kumaresh, the enthusiastic response also reflects the openness of audiences to innovation that remains rooted in tradition. “I genuinely feel we should call our music *shastriya*, which means it is founded on *shastra*, rather than ‘classical’, which refers to a particular historical period. Our music is constantly reimagining itself within the framework of *shastra*. It is a scientific art form, and therefore timeless,” signs of Kumaresh.

(*Tala Pravaham*, rooted in the *Sapta Sooladi talas*, will present its finale, *Eka*, on July 5, at Gayana Samaja, Bengaluru, at 6.30 p.m.)

